THE DIAGNOSTIC LEAP

Growing incidence and awareness as well as early identification have improved the diagnosis rate for autism. Parul Tandon from Bengaluru, mother of seven-year-old Sahana, could diagnose her when she was two. Shilpi Rao in Hyderabad, parent of four-year-old Rohan, went against her family's wishes and took him for a check-up when he was a year and a half.

"Parents are recognising some signs and coming for an examination much more than before," says Dr Sinha. Some early markers are speech delays, sleep issues, gastrointestinal problems, poor eye contact and name response, restlessness and repetitive behaviour. "There is no harm in getting a check-up done if you suspect something versus letting the child go undiagnosed till it is too late."

Delayed speech is the most common sign of autism. "A few meaningful words should come by the age of one or two years. Speech regression, where a child forgets what he or she has said, can also happen," says Dr Kalra. Many families attribute delayed speech to a family pattern. "Or perhaps the parent had mild autism and was never diagnosed. We need to start thinking that if a child does not meet a developmental milestone, we need to ensure that there is no other underlying issue," adds Dr Kalra. Abnormal sleeping patterns in the first year is another symptom that parents miss, mistaking it for milk allergy or abdominal colic.

Doctors insist a professional should make the final diagnosis, not a layperson, or worse, the internet. Fortunately, in Indian cities today, qualified neurological paediatricians and psychiatrists can assess a child's developmental pattern to raise red flags. "If we know of red flag signs, we do a full psychological assessment. We even have one for children less than one year old," explains Dr Sinha. It's vital that such diagnosis happens as early as possible because while autism cannot be cured or reversed, its progression can be halted and the patient's condition improved.

NOT JUST INCLUSION, AUTISTIC CHILDREN NEED INTEGRATION AT SCHOOL TO BE ABLE TO OVERCOME SOCIALISATION PROBLEMS

ADVANCES IN THERAPY

Sukanya Ghosh, 49, recalls how 18 years ago, when she was trying to find treatment for her one-year-old autistic



MANISH RAJPUT

ADITI TREHAN, *Mother of* **ADHYAYAN**, *10, Delhi*

What he is not able to express verbally, Adhyayan, aged 10, accomplishes with his hands. A budding artist and singer, Adhyayan's treatment began when he was two. He attends Shiv Nadar school in Noida, but this is supplemented by special classes at home. Thanks to the one-on-one attention from teachers, Adhyayan is learning to express and be independent. From kitsch elephants on canvas to wall art using sea shells, Adhyayan's art dominates their home. His paintings have also made it to art shows. Edtech entrepreneur Divyav Gokulnath recently purchased some of his paintings at one such show in Delhi. He also sings at various music events in the city. "There are many organisations like Atypical Advantage who are helping to display his work and talents," says his proud mum. The number of organisations available to develop skills of a special child has increased, giving parents like Trehan not just opportunities but also a close knit circle of support.